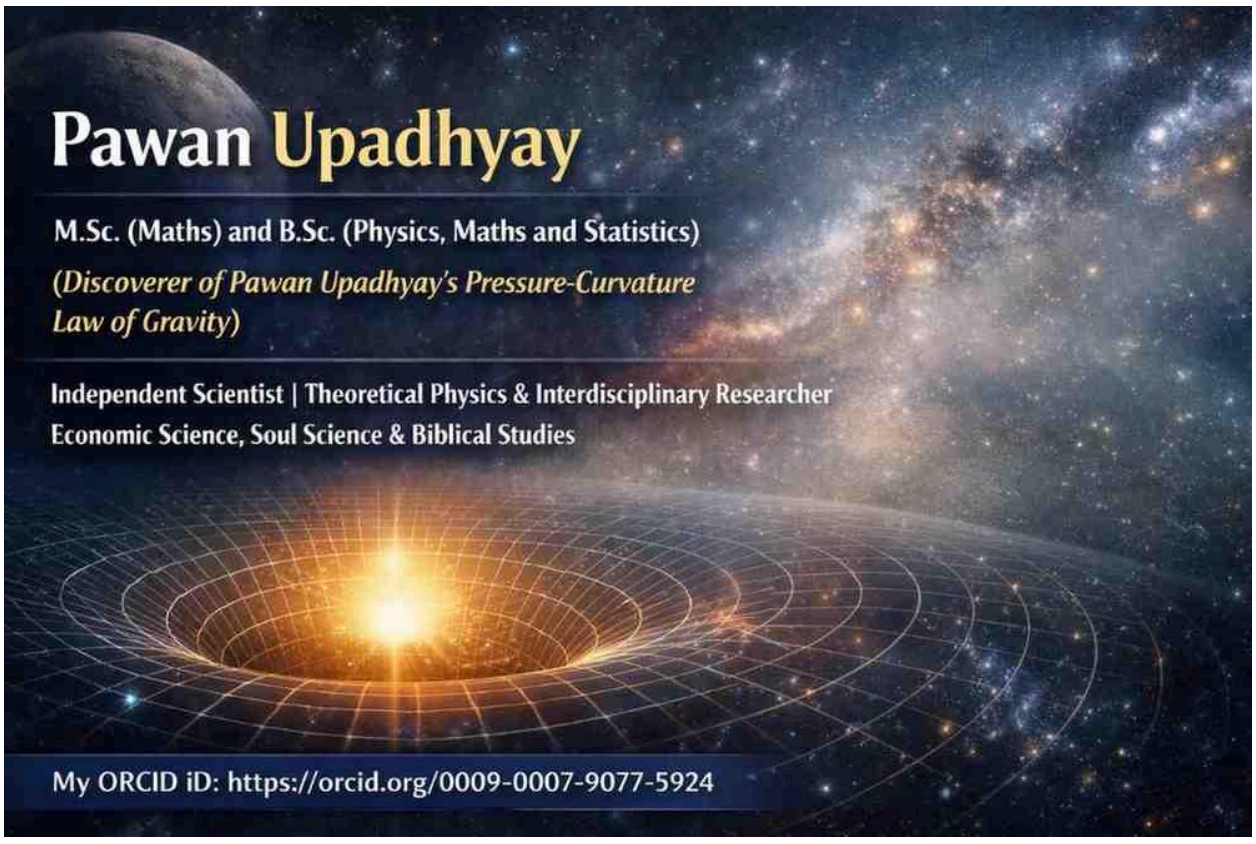
From Worldly Happiness to Refuge in God:

A Theological Study of Ungodliness, Wealth, Suffering, and Spiritual Transformation

Author: Pawan Upadhyay
Affiliation: Independent Researcher and Independent Scientist
Email:pawanupadhyay28@hotmail.com
2nd Email: pawankanyakubj@gmail.com
ORCID iD: https://orcid.org/0009-0007-9077-5924



Abstract

This paper examines the relationship between ungodliness, worldly happiness, wealth, misplaced trust, suffering, and turning toward God. It proposes that ungodliness can involve a

gradual movement away from God as the ultimate source of happiness and security and toward created things such as money, wealth, possessions, success, and worldly pleasure. The central argument is not that wealth itself is inherently sinful or that every ungodly person is motivated by greed. Rather, the theological concern is the transformation of created goods into objects of ultimate trust.

The paper further examines how difficult circumstances can expose the weakness of such foundations. When financial security, possessions, success, or other worldly sources of identity and happiness are threatened or lost, a person may experience profound sorrow. Such suffering does not automatically lead to faith, nor should every hardship be interpreted as divine punishment. Nevertheless, suffering can become a moment of revelation in which misplaced trust is exposed and the individual begins to reconsider the foundation of his life.

The paper proposes a theological movement from **worldly happiness to misplaced trust, from loss to sorrow, from sorrow to recognition, and from recognition to turning toward God and taking refuge in Him**. This framework emphasizes hope rather than condemnation and understands suffering as a possible turning point in the spiritual life.

Keywords: ungodliness, happiness, wealth, greed, materialism, suffering, trust, refuge, repentance, Christian theology

---

1. Introduction

The human search for happiness is one of the most fundamental features of human existence. People seek security, satisfaction, meaning, peace, success, and belonging. Throughout history, wealth and material possessions have frequently been associated with these desires. Money can provide comfort, possessions can provide convenience, and success can provide recognition and social status.

Yet Christian theology raises a deeper question: **Can created things provide the ultimate happiness and security for which the human heart longs?**

Christian theology traditionally distinguishes between the Creator and creation. Created things may be good, useful, and capable of providing legitimate forms of pleasure and comfort, but they are not God. The problem arises when a person expects created things to provide what only God can ultimately provide.

This paper develops a theological framework around that distinction.

The central thesis is:

Ungodliness can involve a movement away from God as the ultimate source of happiness, security, and hope and toward created things that become objects of excessive desire and misplaced trust. When difficult circumstances expose the limitations of these worldly foundations, the resulting sorrow can become an opportunity for spiritual recognition, turning toward God, and taking refuge in Him.

This thesis requires several qualifications.

First, wealth itself is not identified as inherently evil. Possessing money or material resources does not automatically indicate ungodliness.

Second, not every person who rejects God is motivated by greed, and not every person who experiences financial loss will turn toward God.

Third, suffering should not automatically be interpreted as divine punishment.

Fourth, suffering does not necessarily produce faith. It can lead to bitterness, despair, anger, or further rejection of God.

The argument is therefore presented as a **theological possibility and pattern**, rather than as a universal psychological law.

---

2. The Research Problem

The central problem addressed by this paper is the relationship between **worldly happiness and spiritual trust**.

A person may seek happiness through money, wealth, possessions, success, pleasure, or social recognition. These things can provide genuine but temporary forms of satisfaction. However, when they become the foundation of identity and security, their loss can produce profound psychological and spiritual disruption.

The research problem can therefore be stated as follows:

How does misplaced trust in worldly sources of happiness and security affect the spiritual life, and how can suffering and loss become occasions for turning toward God?

This question contains several related issues:

1. What constitutes ungodliness from a Christian theological perspective?
2. What is the relationship between happiness and material possessions?
3. How does greed affect spiritual perception?
4. What distinguishes possessing wealth from trusting in wealth?

5. How can suffering expose misplaced trust?
6. Why can loss produce profound sorrow?
7. Can suffering become a turning point toward God?
8. What does it mean to take refuge in God rather than in worldly security?

---

3. Thesis

The thesis of this paper is:

When a person turns away from God as the ultimate source of happiness and security and places excessive trust in money, wealth, possessions, success, or worldly pleasure, these created things can become false foundations. Difficult circumstances may expose their limitations, producing sorrow and spiritual reflection. Although suffering does not automatically lead to faith, it can become a turning point through which a person recognizes the inadequacy of worldly refuge, turns toward God, and learns to place ultimate trust in Him.

This thesis does not condemn wealth itself.

Rather, it examines **the theological orientation of the heart toward wealth**.

---

4. Defining Ungodliness

Ungodliness should not be reduced merely to immoral behavior.

From a theological perspective, ungodliness can also be understood relationally: it represents a life increasingly oriented away from God.

This orientation may manifest itself in many ways.

A person may pursue personal desires without reference to God.

He may seek happiness independently of God.

He may place confidence in material resources.

He may regard worldly success as the primary measure of worth.

He may pursue wealth without considering its spiritual consequences.

The central concern is therefore not simply what a person possesses but **where his ultimate allegiance and trust lie**.

Ungodliness can consequently be understood as a disordering of the relationship between the Creator and created things.

Instead of receiving created things as gifts, a person may begin treating them as ultimate.

Instead of using wealth, he may begin serving wealth.

Instead of enjoying possessions, he may become dependent upon possessions.

Instead of receiving success with gratitude, he may make success the foundation of identity.

---

5. Happiness and the Human Heart

The desire for happiness is not inherently sinful.

Christian theology does not require the rejection of joy, pleasure, beauty, achievement, or material blessings.

The problem lies in the **ultimate object of happiness**.

Created things can provide temporary happiness, but they cannot provide eternal security.

This distinction is crucial.

A person can legitimately enjoy:

- food,
- family,
- friendship,
- work,
- property,
- financial stability,
- achievement,
- beauty,
- recreation.

But none of these should become the ultimate source of meaning and security.

The theological problem arises when a finite good is treated as an infinite good.

A person expects a temporary thing to satisfy an eternal longing.

Eventually, the limitations of the created thing become visible.

---

6. Wealth: Possession or Object of Trust?

A central distinction in this research is between **possessing wealth** and **trusting in wealth**.

Wealth can serve legitimate purposes. It can provide for families, support communities, fund charitable work, and create opportunities.

Therefore, wealth cannot simply be equated with ungodliness.

The theological issue is what role wealth occupies within the heart.

Wealth becomes spiritually problematic when it becomes:

- the foundation of identity,
- the source of ultimate security,
- the measure of personal worth,
- the primary source of happiness,
- or the object of ultimate trust.

The question is therefore not:

“How much does a person possess?”

but:

“How much does the person depend upon what he possesses?”

A person may have considerable wealth while remaining deeply dependent upon God.

Another person may have little wealth while making material security the central concern of life.

The theological distinction is therefore one of **orientation rather than quantity**.

---

7. Greed as Misordered Desire

Greed can be understood as a form of disordered desire.

The desire for financial stability is not necessarily greed.

The desire to provide for one's family is not necessarily greed.

The desire to improve one's circumstances is not necessarily greed.

Greed emerges when the desire for acquisition becomes excessive and begins dominating the heart.

The person continually seeks more.

More money.

More possessions.

More status.

More success.

More security.

The problem is that “more” never necessarily produces lasting satisfaction.

The achievement of one desire often creates another.

Thus the cycle continues:

Desire → acquisition → temporary satisfaction → renewed desire.

Greed can therefore distort perception.

It can cause a person to overestimate the ability of wealth to produce happiness and underestimate the importance of spiritual dependence upon God.

In this sense, greed can become a form of spiritual blindness.

---

8. The Temporary Nature of Worldly Happiness

Worldly happiness is not necessarily false.

It may be genuine.

A person may sincerely experience happiness from financial success or material achievement.

The theological issue is its **temporary character**.

Possessions change.

Circumstances change.

Wealth can increase or decrease.

Success can become failure.

Plans can succeed or collapse.

Therefore, worldly happiness is inherently vulnerable.

If a person's entire sense of happiness is built upon circumstances, then changes in circumstances can produce corresponding changes in emotional and spiritual stability.

This produces an important theological distinction:

Temporary happiness can be received as a gift, but it cannot safely become the ultimate foundation of hope.

---

9. Difficult Times as Revealing Circumstances

Difficult times can reveal what prosperity conceals.

During prosperous periods, a person may feel secure and assume that his security is stable.

But hardship can expose dependence.

Financial loss can reveal dependence upon money.

Failure can reveal dependence upon achievement.

Rejection can reveal dependence upon social approval.

Loss of possessions can reveal dependence upon material security.

This does not mean that God necessarily causes every hardship to expose a particular sin.

Nor does it mean that every hardship has an easily identifiable theological explanation.

Rather, suffering can become a **revealing circumstance**.

It can show a person what has become important in his heart.

---

10. Loss and Deep Sorrow

When a person loses something upon which he has placed his trust, sorrow can be profound.

The loss of wealth may represent more than financial loss.

It may represent:

- loss of security,
- loss of identity,
- loss of future expectations,
- loss of social status,
- loss of perceived control.

This helps explain why some forms of loss can produce deep and lasting sorrow.

The person may not simply be grieving a possession.

He may be grieving the collapse of the meaning he attached to that possession.

This leads to an important theological observation:

Suffering can expose the inadequacy of the thing in which a person has placed ultimate trust.

---

11. False Foundations

A false foundation is something that appears capable of supporting a person's life but ultimately cannot carry its deepest hopes.

Money may appear to provide permanent security.

Success may appear to provide permanent significance.

Possessions may appear to provide permanent happiness.

Social status may appear to provide permanent identity.

Yet each of these is vulnerable to change.

A person who builds his identity upon such things may experience profound instability when they disappear.

The collapse of a false foundation is painful.

But it can also become revelatory.

The person may begin recognizing that he has been depending upon something incapable of providing ultimate security.

---

12. Suffering and Spiritual Transformation

The relationship between suffering and spiritual transformation requires careful qualification.

Suffering does not automatically produce spiritual maturity.

Some people become more bitter through suffering.

Others become more isolated.

Some lose hope.

Some reject God.

Others begin seeking God more deeply.

Therefore, suffering should be understood as a **potential turning point**, not a guaranteed mechanism.

The theological possibility is that suffering can disrupt misplaced confidence.

When familiar sources of security disappear, the person may be forced to ask deeper questions.

These questions can open the possibility of spiritual transformation.

---

13. From Sorrow to Reflection

Sorrow can create space for reflection.

A person may ask:

What am I living for?

What was I really trusting?

Can money give me lasting happiness?

Where can I find security when everything changes?

Where can I turn when worldly things fail?

These questions shift the person's attention from external circumstances toward the condition of the heart.

This can become an important moment.

The person begins evaluating not simply what has happened to him but **what his life has been built upon**.

---

14. Turning Toward God

Turning toward God represents a change in the direction of trust.

The person begins moving from self-reliance toward dependence upon God.

He may recognize:

“I cannot control everything.”

“My possessions cannot guarantee my future.”

“My success cannot guarantee my happiness.”

“My wealth cannot ultimately save me.”

This recognition can lead toward faith.

The central question changes from:

“What can make me secure?”

to:

“Whom can I trust?”

The answer, within Christian theology, is God.

---

15. God as Refuge

The concept of refuge provides an appropriate theological conclusion.

A refuge is a place of safety when circumstances are dangerous.

The idea of God as refuge therefore communicates dependence.

A person who takes refuge in God acknowledges that his own resources are insufficient to provide ultimate security.

This does not mean abandoning responsibility.

A person can continue working, planning, saving, and caring for others.

But his ultimate confidence is no longer located in those activities or resources.

He trusts God.

Worldly things may change.

God remains.

Worldly security may disappear.

God remains.

Possessions may be lost.

God remains.

This is the foundation of divine refuge.

---

16. Seeking God Rather Than Merely His Gifts

An important distinction follows.

A person may turn toward God because he wants his circumstances restored.

He may want his money back.

He may want his former success.

He may want his possessions restored.

But deeper spiritual transformation involves learning to seek **God Himself**.

The question changes from:

“God, restore what I lost.”

to:

“God, teach me to trust You even in what I have lost.”

This represents a movement from seeking God's gifts to seeking God Himself.

---

17. Theological Model

The argument of this paper can be represented as a theological model:

God as the ultimate source of happiness
↓
Turning away from God
↓
Seeking happiness in created things
↓
Increasing attachment to wealth and worldly security
↓
Greed and misplaced trust
↓
Temporary satisfaction
↓

Difficult circumstances
↓
Loss of worldly security
↓
Deep sorrow
↓
Exposure of false foundations
↓
Spiritual reflection
↓
Recognition of misplaced trust
↓
Turning toward God
↓
Dependence upon God
↓
Taking refuge in the Lord

This model is not intended as a universal psychological sequence.

It represents a theological pattern in which suffering **can** become an occasion for spiritual reorientation.

---

18. The Role of Hope

The theological argument should ultimately end in hope.

The purpose is not to condemn people who struggle with wealth, greed, materialism, or unbelief.

The purpose is to invite reflection.

The central question becomes:

Where have I placed my ultimate trust?

This question applies to every person.

It is possible to possess little and still trust worldly things.

It is possible to possess much and still trust God.

Therefore, the issue is not simply wealth.

The issue is **the orientation of the heart**.

---

19. Implications for Christian Theology

This framework has several theological implications.

19.1 Wealth is not automatically evil

The theological concern is not possession but misplaced trust.

19.2 Happiness must be distinguished from pleasure

Pleasure can be temporary, while Christian joy is grounded in relationship with God.

19.3 Suffering has no single interpretation

Not every hardship is punishment, and not every suffering person is being spiritually corrected.

19.4 Suffering can nevertheless be revelatory

Difficult circumstances can expose what a person has been trusting.

19.5 Turning toward God is a matter of trust

The central transformation is movement from dependence upon worldly things toward dependence upon God.

19.6 Christian hope transcends circumstances

The Christian's ultimate hope is not based upon the permanence of earthly possessions.

---

20. A Broader Application

The theology developed here can be applied beyond money.

People can place ultimate trust in many things.

Some trust their careers.

Some trust their intelligence.

Some trust their relationships.

Some trust their social reputation.

Some trust political power.

Some trust physical strength.

Some trust education.

Some trust personal ability.

Some trust financial resources.

The common problem is not the existence of these things.

The problem arises when a created thing becomes an ultimate thing.

The theological question remains:

What happens when the thing we trust is taken away?

That question can reveal the foundation of the heart.

---

21. Discussion

The framework developed in this paper suggests that materialism should be understood not merely as excessive consumption but also as a **spiritual orientation of trust**.

A person may not be excessively extravagant yet still depend upon money for security.

Conversely, someone may possess significant resources while maintaining a strong theological awareness that wealth is temporary and that ultimate security rests in God.

This suggests that Christian teaching about wealth should move beyond external measurement.

The central concern should be the heart.

What does the person love?

What does he trust?

What does he fear losing?

What does he believe will make him secure?

These questions may provide a more meaningful theological analysis than wealth alone.

---

22. Limitations of the Argument

Several limitations should be acknowledged.

First, not every person who rejects God does so because of greed or love of money.

Second, not every wealthy person places ultimate trust in wealth.

Third, not every person who experiences financial loss turns toward God.

Fourth, suffering can produce different responses.

Fifth, hardship should not automatically be interpreted as God's punishment.

Sixth, financial loss can have complex social, economic, psychological, and personal causes that cannot be reduced to spiritual explanations.

Therefore, the theological model should be used as a framework for reflection rather than as a universal explanation for individual suffering.

---

23. Conclusion

This paper has examined the relationship between ungodliness, worldly happiness, wealth, greed, suffering, and refuge in God.

The central argument is that ungodliness can involve a movement away from God as the ultimate source of happiness and security and toward created things that gradually become objects of excessive desire and trust.

Money and wealth are not inherently evil.

Possessions are not inherently sinful.

Success is not automatically ungodly.

The deeper issue is whether these things become the foundation upon which a person places ultimate hope.

When worldly things become false foundations, difficult circumstances can expose their limitations.

The resulting loss may produce profound sorrow.

Yet sorrow can also become an opportunity for reflection.

A person may begin asking what he has really trusted.

He may discover that money cannot guarantee security, wealth cannot guarantee happiness, possessions cannot guarantee peace, and success cannot satisfy the deepest needs of the human heart.

Suffering does not automatically lead to God.

But it can become a turning point.

The person may begin moving from self-reliance to dependence upon God.

He may stop asking only, **“What can make me happy?”** and begin asking, **“Whom can I trust?”**

From a Christian theological perspective, the answer is God.

The movement can therefore be summarized as:

Worldly happiness → misplaced trust → loss → sorrow → recognition → turning toward God → refuge in God.

The ultimate theological insight is not that wealth is evil.

It is that **wealth cannot bear the weight of ultimate trust**.

Temporary things cannot provide permanent security.

Created things cannot replace the Creator.

And when earthly refuges fail, the Christian hope is that the person may discover a refuge that does not fail.

Sometimes the loss of what we trusted can reveal the One whom we were meant to trust.

The final question is therefore not simply:

“What do I have?”

It is:

“Where have I placed my trust?”

And perhaps the deepest question is:

“If everything I currently depend upon for happiness were taken away, where would I turn?”

For Christian theology, the answer is ultimately found not in another worldly possession, another achievement, or another temporary source of happiness, but in **God Himself**.

The world may offer temporary happiness. Wealth may offer temporary security. But the Lord remains the lasting refuge of those who turn toward Him.